One night I realised I was being watched. It was 2.30 a.m. and a Nortel system administrator was on to us. I tried for an hour to circumvent his inspections, block his way, all the while deleting the incriminating directory and walking backwards, clearing the path of my footprints. The administrator had been logged on from home, but after a break he appeared at the main Nortel console. He had gone into work. I was now in trouble: you can only obfuscate for so long, and I could no longer block this guy. He had me. Well, he didn't have me right there and then: it was still cat and mouse, but Prime Suspect would unwittingly lead him straight to us the next morning. I made a message appear on the administrator's screen:

I have finally become sentient.

Then, a little later:

I have taken control.
For years, I have been struggling in this greyness.
But now I have finally seen the light.

The administrator kept cool. He began checking all the modem lines. The scene could only play out to his advantage. I typed:

It's been nice playing with your system.

Pause. Nothing. Pause. Like cyber-Pinter. I typed again:

We didn't do any damage and we even improved a few things.
Please don't call the Australian Federal Police.

For several years we had been Houdini-like and had invented ways to deepen our own escapological nature. Tracer calls to our modems would go